Module 2:Interview Skills

Department of English
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BELH 0021: English for Professional Purposes II

Understanding the Interview Framework

An interview is a structured meeting between an employer and a prospective employee to judge whether the candidate matches the role, the work culture, and the team. Recruiters are not only checking knowledge; they are also assessing personality, goals, credentials, readiness, and professional attitude.

Suitable for the role?

skills, credentials, and basic eligibility

Can do the job?

technical ability and problem-solving approach

Will do the job?

motivation, responsibility, and work ethic

Fit with the team?

communication style and cultural compatibility

- A strong interview answer combines knowledge, examples, and clarity of expression.
- For B.Tech students, projects, internships, labs, hackathons, and team-tasks become the best evidence.

Pre-Interview Preparation

Success begins before the interview starts. Prepare both your content and your professional presence.

Organization Research

- Understand the company's products, services, values, and recent achievements.
- Read the job description carefully and connect it to your skills and projects.
- Use the company website, LinkedIn page, and placement notices for focused research.

Self-Analysis

- Identify your strengths, weaknesses, interests, and career goals.
- Select marketable skills such as teamwork, honesty, communication, and initiative.
- Prepare 2–3 short stories from projects, internships, labs, or competitions.

Your 60-Second Introduction

- Mention your degree, branch, semester/year, and one strong academic or project area.
- Add what you are currently working on and what kind of role you want next.
- End with how your skills can add value to the company.

Logistics

- Arrive 10–15 minutes early or join the online room a few minutes before time.
- Keep extra copies of your resume, references, ID, and required documents ready.
- Plan formal attire in advance: clean, well-fitted, and professional.

Communication and Professional Presence

Use Language that Sounds Professional

- "I majored in Electronics / Mechanical / CSE."
- "I perform well under pressure and communicate my approach clearly."
- "I have worked in team-based projects and can take ownership of tasks."
- "My salary expectations are in line with the role and my qualifications."

Avoid these Habits

- Fillers such as "um," "kinda," "basically," "actually," and "whatever."
- Negative words like "hate," blame, or excuses about past teachers or supervisors.
- Empty clichés such as "I am a perfectionist" without evidence.
- Long answers that lose focus and do not address the question directly.

Body Language + Virtual Interview Tips

- Maintain eye contact, sit upright, smile naturally, and listen fully before answering.
- For online rounds, test your camera, microphone, internet, and background in advance.

Advanced Communication Skills

Effective Phrases for Engineering Students

Education

“I majored in Engineering” or "I graduated as a Mechanical Engineer in 20XX"

Professional Profile

“I perform well under pressure,” “I have a can-do attitude,” or “I am results-driven”

Experience

“I have a proven track record in [Field]” or “I am used to working in a busy environment

Salary (if pressed)

“My salary expectations are in line with my qualifications and education”

Words and Phrases to Avoid

Filler Words

“Um” and “Kinda” make you look less polished and introduce vagueness

Negative Language

Never use the word “Hate” when discussing past

Clichés

Avoid calling yourself a “Perfectionist,” as it is considered a meaningless cliché

Casual Fillers

Avoid “Basically,” “ Actually”, “Stuff,” and “Whatever,” which diminish your achievements and sound immature

Master the Interview Formats

For engineering students, each format checks a different kind of readiness.

Screening Round

- Short phone or video round to check minimum fit.
- Keep your introduction clear and your internet stable.

Panel Interview

- Several interviewers may ask from different perspectives.
- Greet everyone and share eye contact across the panel.

Technical / Logic Round

- May include coding, circuits, design, estimation, or problem-solving.
- Explain your reasoning step by step instead of jumping to an answer.

HR / Behavioural Round

- Focuses on attitude, teamwork, values, and motivation.
- Use specific examples from projects and internships.

Tip for B.Tech students: revise your final-year project, internship work, favorite subject, and one real teamwork example before any round.

Answering Technique: The STAR Method

Use STAR when the interviewer asks about past behaviour, teamwork, deadlines, failure, conflict, or initiative.

S – Situation	T – Task	A – Action	R – Result
Describe the context briefly.	State the goal, challenge, or responsibility.	Explain exactly what you did.	Share the outcome and the lesson learned.

Engineering Example

S: Two days before our project demo, the prototype sensor started giving unstable readings.

T: I had to help the team present a working system on time.

A: I recalibrated the sensor, shifted to a backup module, redistributed testing tasks, and updated our faculty mentor.

R: The demo ran successfully, we met the deadline, and I learned to build backup plans early.

Why STAR works

It keeps answers structured, specific, and memorable.

Frequently Asked Questions: What Your Answer Should Show

Question	What to include in your answer
Tell me about yourself.	Degree + branch + one strong project/internship + current focus + career goal.
Why should we hire you?	Mention three strengths that match the job and support them with a real example.
What is your weakness?	Choose a real but manageable weakness and explain how you are improving it.
How do you work under pressure?	Show prioritisation, calm thinking, time management, and communication.
Where do you see yourself in five years?	Align your growth with the company's opportunities and learning path.

Keep your answers honest, concise, and supported by evidence from academic or real-life experience.

Technical and Situational Questions

How to Handle a Tricky Question

- Clarify the problem before you answer.
- State any assumptions when data is missing.
- Explain your reasoning aloud, step by step.
- Mention trade-offs, risks, or alternatives where relevant.
- End with a practical conclusion or recommendation.

Practice Prompts for B.Tech Students

- What would you do if project priorities changed suddenly?
- How would you deal with a teammate who is not contributing?
- If a customer becomes frustrated and asks for your manager, what do you do?
- Which would you rather have: a trunk full of nickels or a trunk half full of dimes?
- How does your college project experience relate to this job?

For estimation questions, do not panic—state your assumptions first and show your logic clearly.

Mock Interview and Day-of-Interview Checklist

1. Simulate

- Dress properly and treat the session like a real interview.
- Begin with confidence, greeting, and a smile.

2. Review

- Record the session and check posture, fillers, eye contact, and clarity.
- Notice whether you sound the way you intend to sound.

3. Refine

- Improve your 60-second introduction and STAR stories.
- Practice weak areas until your answer feels natural and precise.

Checklist before the final interview

- Carry 2–3 copies of your resume and keep project details fresh in memory.
- Test laptop, charger, earphones, internet, and required software for online rounds.
- Reach 10–15 minutes early, stay calm, and listen carefully before each response.

Why it matters: practice reduces anxiety and improves confidence, clarity, and control.

Classroom Activity

Activity 1: Build Your 60-Second Introduction

- State your name, degree, branch, and current year/semester.
- Mention one project, internship, or skill area that represents you best.
- Add your career interest and the value you can bring to the employer.

Activity 2: Pair Practice Questions

- Tell me about yourself.
- Why should we hire you?
- Tell me about a project challenge you handled.
- How do you deal with pressure or teamwork problems?
- Where do you see yourself in five years?

Task: Use the STAR method in at least two answers and focus on clarity, confidence, and evidence.

Use the given questions to practice your mock sessions

1. Introductory & General
Question 1: "Tell me a little about yourself."
Probable Start: Focus on your academic journey and professional interests.
Sample: "I am a final-year B. Tech student majoring in [Your Major]. My interest in this field began with my fascination for [Concept], which led me to choose this path at [University Name]. Throughout my studies, I have focused on [Skill/Project]...“

Question 2: "Why should I hire you?"
Probable Start: Identify three themes/strengths that match the job description.
Sample: "You should hire me because I bring a combination of [Strength 1], [Strength 2], and [Strength 3]. For example, during my recent student project, I demonstrated [Strength 1] by...“

Question 3: "What do you know about our company?" Probable Start: Show you have done your "homework."
Sample: "I have been following your company's progress, specifically your recent [News Item/Project].
I am impressed by your commitment to [Company Value] and see how my skills in [Your Skill] could contribute to your goals of..."

Question 4: "What is your weakness?"
Probable Start: Choose a real, work-related weakness and explain how you are improving.
Sample: "One area I am working to improve is [Weakness, e.g., Public Speaking]. While it isn't critical to this role, I recognize its importance, so I have been [Action you are taking, e.g., attending workshops] to overcome it..."

Question 5: "How do you work under pressure?"

Probable Start: Walk the middle ground—show you are capable without sounding like you *only* work under pressure.

Sample: "I perform well under pressure because I have learned to prioritize tasks effectively.

For example, when faced with multiple deadlines last semester, I [Specific Action taken]...“

Question 6: "Where do you see yourself in five years?"

Probable Start: Align your goals with the company's opportunities.

Sample: "In five years, I hope to have mastered [Specific Skill] and be contributing to larger-scale projects within an organization like yours. I am looking for a role that offers natural progression and the opportunity to...“

Question 7: Tell me about a difficult decision you have made or an obstacle you overcame.

Probable Start: Identify a real challenge, such as a conflict or a technical hurdle, and focus on your **analytical and collaborative approach**.

Sample Sentences: "During a major team project, we faced a significant obstacle when our primary data source became unavailable. I had to decide whether to delay the project or find an alternative method. I chose to **collaborate with the IT department** to source secondary data. As a result, we completed the project on time with 95% accuracy."

Question 8: Tell me about a time you demonstrated leadership or initiative.

Probable Start: Focus on a time you identified a need and **stepped up without being asked**, showing your motivation. **Sample Sentences:** "I demonstrated initiative when I noticed our student organization's fundraising efforts were declining. My task was to find a way to **motivate the team** and increase contributions. I designed a new social media campaign and coordinated three local events. This resulted in a **20% increase in funds** compared to the previous year."

Question 9: Describe a time you went above and beyond what was expected.

Probable Start: Share a story that shows you **added value to the company or group** by doing more than the minimum requirements.

Sample Sentences: "While interning, I was tasked with basic market research. However, I realized that a **detailed competitor analysis** would be more beneficial for the upcoming strategy meeting. I spent extra hours compiling a comprehensive report on three main competitors.

My supervisor was impressed and used my findings to **refine the project goals**."

Question 10: . Tell me about a time when a classmate or co-worker criticized your work.

Probable Start: Frame the criticism as **constructive feedback** and show that you can handle it professionally and without being defensive.

Sample Sentences: "During a peer review, a classmate pointed out that my technical calculations lacked sufficient detail. Instead of

becoming defensive, I **listened with an open mind** to understand their perspective. I revised my work to include step-by-step logic, which the

professor later noted as a **strength of the final report**."

Question 11 : Tell me about a time you had to deal with a crisis.

Probable Start: Detail a high-pressure situation where you had to **remain calm and collect your thoughts** to find a solution.

Sample Sentences: "Our project team faced a crisis when a key member had to leave unexpectedly two days before the deadline.

I took a moment to **collect my thoughts** and reassessed our remaining tasks. I redistributed the workload based on each member's strengths.

We managed to submit a **high-quality project** exactly on time."

Question 12: Describe a time you failed to meet a deadline. What did you learn?

Probable Start: Be **honest about the mistake**, explain the repercussions, and emphasize the lesson learned to prevent it from happening again.

Sample Sentences: "I once failed to meet a deadline for a lab report because I had **too much on my plate** and didn't prioritize correctly. The repercussion was a grade deduction for the team. From this, I learned to use a **digital tracking system** for multiple projects.
I now **stay focused** by setting internal milestones a week before every actual deadline.“

Situational and Problem-Solving Questions

13. What would you do if project priorities changed suddenly?
14. How would you deal with a team member who isn't contributing?
15. If a customer becomes frustrated with our product and wants to talk to your manager, what do you do?
16. Which would you rather have: a trunk full of nickels or a trunk half full of dimes?

Teamwork & Environment

17. How do you feel about working in groups?
18. What role do you tend to play in groups (Leader, Idea Generator, Finisher, or Analyzer)?
19. Describe your ideal work environment.
20. Have you had difficulty getting-along with a professor or supervisor? How did you handle it?

Academic & Experience

21. How does your college education or project experience relate to this job?

22. Which classes in your major did you like the best and why?

23. What job-related skills have you developed through your training?

24. Did you work while going to college? What did you learn the best and why?

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